

CHRONICLES OF THE STILL LAKE

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ON FLOWCRAFT

a reader's companion

ECHOCRAFT

ESSENCEBENDING

VOIDSHAPING

LOREFORGING

STREAMBINDING

LIFEWAVING

Six forms, and every road between.

BILL McKIBBIN

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A CHRONICLES OF THE STILL LAKE COMPANION

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On Flowcraft is a companion to the world of the Chronicles of the Still Lake, written for readers on the author's list. The legends themselves, *Stories From The Still Lake*, are free for anyone at billmckibbin.com.

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*Set down for the households of the tested, by one who has carried the bowls
these forty years.*

To the Household

The bowls do not lie. They do not say much, either.

Your child has been tested.

Perhaps we came to your hall, and there was a dinner, and the young ones were brought in scrubbed and solemn to touch the water. Perhaps you stood in a market square in your good coat, holding a nine-year-old's hand in a line of other good coats and other nine-year-olds. It makes no difference to the bowls. The water moved, or it did not. You hold this text because it moved.

I will tell you plainly what I will not do in these pages, so that you are not reading for it. I will not teach the working of any form. That is not a secret kept from you. It is the shape of the thing. Craft passes hand to hand or not at all, and a page has no hands. When your child is ready, a teacher will be found, and what passes between them will not be written down by anyone, because it cannot be.

What I can give you is everything else, and everything else is a great deal. The Lake. The vessel your child is. The draws, from the lightest to the one I will spend few words on. The six forms, what each one asks of the person who works it, and what each one costs. And the rare vessels the bowls so often fail to find, of whom I will speak honestly, because assessors owe the world more honesty on that count than we have generally paid.

Households fear what they do not understand, and grow careless around what they half understand. This text is against both. Read it

slowly. Keep it somewhere it can be found again. You will want it in a year, when the fear has worn off.

I · The Lake and the Ripple

Still water is not idle water.

All craft is drawing, and all drawing is from The Still Lake.

Where it lies, no one can tell you. No road arrives at it. No one living has stood on its shore, and the dead who claimed to were liars in life as well. And yet every Flowcrafter who has ever warmed a basin or coaxed a hinge or knit a bone has drawn from it, the way every well in every village draws on rain that fell somewhere no one was watching. Your child does not go to the Lake. Your child draws from it, and it is the Lake the draw finds.

Now the part that every household must understand, because everything else in this text stands on it.

The surface of the Lake is time.

I did not write that to confuse you. It is the plainest fact in the craft, and the one that governs all the others. When your child draws it in, the drawing makes a ripple, as drawing any water does. But a ripple on that water does not spread across a pond. It spreads across the years. It does not ask which way the years run, either. It runs into the years behind us and the years ahead of us alike, and the greater the draw, the farther the ripples run. And one thing more, because a household should have the whole of it: the oldest records hold that in the greatest troublings the ripple does not run evenly, but harder into one direction of the years than the other. Why, none can say.

A small draw makes a small ripple. A great draw sends its ripples out into seasons no one now living will see, and seasons no one now

living remembers. What a ripple does when it arrives there is a question assessors are asked at every second table, and here is the honest answer: we do not know, and neither does anyone who tells you otherwise. What we know is what every grandmother in every village knows, which is that it is better to trouble the water less than more. You have seen men glance at standing water when the weather goes strange. That habit is older than any of us, and it is correct.

This is why the reverence exists, and why it is not what the pious make of it. Reverence for the Lake is not kneeling. Nobody kneels to a well. Reverence is a way of working: take what the work needs, take no more, and let the surface settle behind you. The finest Flowcrafters I have known were not the deepest drawers. They were the most skilled. If you learn one thing from these pages, learn to prize a skilled child over a strong one.

The strong ones make ripples.

II · The Vessel

A well is not better than a thimble. It is only deeper.

Your child is a vessel: one of the rare souls that can draw from The Still Lake at all. When we say the word, we mean two things, and the bowls read both.

The first is Shape: which of the flows answer your child, and so what form of Flowcraft they can draw. Not every flow answers every drawer. One child draws and the stone leans toward them; another draws the same way and the stone sits like stone, but a bruise suddenly heals. Shape is settled before we ever arrive. It is discovered, never chosen, and no amount of wishing, praying, or paying has ever changed it. I have watched lords attempt all three. The bowls were not moved, and neither was I.

The second is Size: how deep they can reach into The Still Lake and draw the waters into them. Here the old words are the best ones: there are thimbles, there are channels, and there are wells. The shapers of quiet have their own pair of words for it, the lesser quiet and the great quiet, and the words differ but the truth does not. Size, like Shape, is born and not built. A thimble does not become a well. I will say that again, because more misery has come through this particular door than any other I know: a thimble does not become a well, and a household that spends its love trying to deepen a child will spoil a perfectly good thimble and get no well for it.

What a household should actually hope for, I will come to at the end.

Now, our coming. In the named houses, and above all in the houses where craft is known to run in the line, the assessing is an event. There is a dinner. There is sometimes a harper. We would rather there were not, but forty years have taught me that telling a great house not to make an occasion of a thing is itself an occasion. Everywhere else we come with the season, to the market day, and the children whose ninth birthday that season held are brought to us in the square. Why the ninth year? Because it has always been the ninth year. Assessors inherit more than bowls.

Whether in the hall or the square, the testing is the same. Wet brass, a child's hand, and an assessor watching the water. If it moves, we read what we can: the Shape, as near as the bowls will show it, and the Size, in the old rough measures. A channel's depth. A well past sounding. The words your family was given.

Here is what the bowls did not tell you, and what you must not believe they told you.

They did not tell you how good your child will be. Proficiency is not in the water. It is in the years, and in the teacher, and in the child's own patience, and I have known channels who out-drew wells their whole lives because the well never learned thrift and the channel never wasted a drop. Skill in this craft is economy. Training a Flowcrafter is not teaching them to take more. It is teaching them to do more with less taken. Remember that when your child's teacher seems to be teaching them almost nothing. The teacher is teaching them the important things, skill and patience.

They did not tell you what your child will do with any of it. There is no bowl for character. I have tested children whose water barely stirred who grew into workers half a province blesses at planting, and I have tested one or two whose bowls sang, and whom

I think of on bad nights. The water is the water. The child is the child.

And they may not have told you everything that is in the water. A loud flow fills the brass by itself, and if a quieter one runs beneath it, the bowls have no second tongue to tell of it. What that can mean at a family's table deserves its own chapter, and it has one, near the end.

III · The Draws

Draw with the hand, not the arm.

There are names for the ways of drawing, and they go up like a ladder. Most working lives are spent entirely on the bottom two rungs, and that is not a small life. That is a good life.

The Surface Draw, which working folk call the Skim. The lightest touch there is. Warming water, easing a squall of fever, settling a fretful animal. A skim barely dimples the Lake, and a Flowcrafter in good practice can skim all day and sleep well after. When your child begins, they will begin here, and they should stay here longer than they want to.

The Channel Draw, the Flowthread. The working draw. A steady, held draw, drawn thin and even, the way a good spinner feeds a thread. This is the draw of the trades: the mender at her bench, the bender walking a wall seam by seam. A channel draw sustained with skill leaves the surface close to still, and learning to hold one is most of an apprenticeship.

The Pulse Draw, the Plunge. The draw of need. Sudden, whole, unplanned, the draw a person makes the instant before the cart tips or the scaffold goes. It saves lives, and every assessor honors it. But understand what it is: an unpracticed hand thrust deep in haste. It takes what it takes, it ripples as it pleases, and the one who plunged has no say in either. A child given to plunging is not brave; they are a child whose teacher must begin sooner, and work harder.

The Deep Draw, which the records call the Sinking. Here the drawer does not dip. They go down, in the manner of a diver rather

than a dipper, and bring up what shallow drawing never could. The great workings live here, and so do their prices. A Deep Draw is measured in days of payment: days of sleep, of weakened hands, of the world sounding far away. Those who work at this depth do so seldom, prepare long, and are watched over after. If your child never sinks once in their life, nothing was wasted. Most never do.

The Mirror Draw, the Echopath. I set it down so that the ladder is whole, and I will honor it in the assessors' way, which is briefly. Of this draw the records say little and assessors say less. It belongs mostly to the listeners, and the few who work it do not describe it, and I will not guess where they would not speak.

And there is a last thing, and it is not a rung.

Overdraw. The draw past what the vessel carries. I told you a thimble does not become a well. Overdraw is what happens when someone, in ambition or in desperation, behaves for one reaching moment as if that were not true. I will not dress this in craft-talk. The Lake does not punish; the Lake is water; there is no malice in what follows, and no mercy either. The vessel takes in more than it holds. What is ruined is not repaired. Of the ones I have known of, none came back the whole of what they were, and the kindest accounting I can give is that some did not come back at all. No teacher teaches it, no record praises it, and no household that reads this page attentively will ever need it explained twice.

That is all the words I will spend there. The ladder is for climbing slowly. Most lives are the bottom rungs, lived well.

IV · The Six Forms

Six doors into one house.

The forms are six. You will hear them named finely and named plainly, and both sets of names are true. What follows is what each form asks of its worker, what it costs, and how you will know it in the world. Costs first, always, in this house. Any fool can tell you what a craft gives.

Essencebending. The benders, folk say. Stone, water, iron, timber, air: the stuff of the world, asked to be otherwise. This is the form the world sees most, because its work stands where everyone can walk past it. The wall that holds where walls should not. The ford that is somehow always shallowest right where the road wants it. Bending asks patience above everything, because the world prefers to be asked slowly, and what is asked unwillingly answers wrong. Benders have a saying: a raised thing is a thing already half-asked. What hands have quarried, carted, and set answers far more readily than what has lain where the world put it, and a good bender reads a place the way you read a face, finding what in it is already half willing. The cost is labor. The body pays as though the back had done the work, and an old bender's hands show it plainly.

Streambinding. The binders. Rhythm, timing, the body and the moment brought into one agreement. You will know a binder as everyone knows one: by the sense, watching them work or fight or simply carry a full tray down stairs, that the world has agreed to arrive a half-beat late for them. The form asks trust. The body must be allowed to know before the mind does, and minds surrender that

precedence very unwillingly, which is why binders are trained young if they are trained well. The cost is the plainest of the six: it spends. However far the moment carried them, the body spends as if it had run every step, and the reckoning arrives all at once, after, in the arms and in the knees.

Loreforging. The gravers. This is craft laid into metal and made to stay: rings, charms, tokens, letters fine as frost that no one else can read back. A graver writes into the made thing what a body has forgotten how to do for itself, and the body, wearing it, is reminded. The steadied heart. The childbed token. Understand what this means for a household: of all the forms, this is the one whose work outlives its worker, and gravers carry that weight in both directions. Some gravings are written to one blood, and to one blood only, and that writing, once written, cannot be unwritten by any hand living, including the hand that wrote it. A graver's decisions are permanent in a way no other worker's are, and the good ones are slow, and the slowness is the goodness. The cost climbs with the depth of the writing. The common tokens are honest work, no worse than a smith's day. The great gravings take from the graver something that is slow to fill again, and every graver knows a story about one who wrote too deep.

Echocraft. The listeners. Of the six, this is the form households know least, and I will go gently, because gentleness is the whole matter of it. Things hold what has happened near them. A room where grief has lived long keeps a grain of that grief the way a hearth keeps warmth after the fire is out, and a listener, entering, knows. A tool used a lifetime by one pair of hands remembers something of the hands. What Echocraft asks is exactly what its plain name says: listening, which sounds easy, and is the hardest asking on

this list, because the world never stops talking and the listener cannot fully stop hearing. The cost follows from the gift. What a listener takes up does not always set itself back down. Grievances not their own arrive as if they were, and joys too, though grief carries farther, as it does in all things. A household raising a listener learns small mercies: a new-built room to sleep in, young tools, quiet. An old house is a loud house, for them.

Voidshaping. The shapers of quiet. Where the other five forms move something, this one stills something, and folk have never fully trusted it for exactly that reason, and folk are not entirely wrong. A shaper makes quiet the way a lamp makes light: around themselves, out to an edge. Sound lies down inside it, and more than sound. The old words for a shaper's Size, the lesser quiet and the great quiet, you have already met. What the form asks is stillness of the worker. You cannot pour quiet out of an unquiet vessel; every shaper's training is first the training of the shaper, and their teachers are the strictest and their apprenticeships the longest. The cost is the strangest on this list, and the hardest to set down in plain words. Shapers come back slowly from long workings, as swimmers come back from cold water: gradually, and not all at once, and wanting a moment to themselves before they speak. Give them the moment. It is not sulking. Something in a person goes very still to make that stillness, and it is owed its slow walk back.

Lifeweaving. The weavers, the menders. I have put it last on purpose, and if you have heard anything at all about the forms before this text reached you, you have likely heard why. So let it be said in an assessor's plain words, once, where a household can keep it.

Every other form on this list draws from The Still Lake alone; the working of another form may cost the body a toll, but it is not taking from the body. Weaving draws from The Still Lake and from the weaver.

That is the law of the form, and there is no working around it. Flesh is dear, and mending it is dear, and the second purse the craft opens is the weaver's own. And the law runs further, and a household must know how it runs: the smaller the vessel and the greener the hand, the more the work takes from the worker. A great weaver in long practice pays for a hard mending in sleep and in shaking hands. A small or a new one, reaching at the same wound, pays out of deeper stores than sleep. This is why weavers are trained more slowly than anyone, held back from grave work longest, and watched at it as a miller watches a new hand near the stones. And it is why, if your child's water showed weaving, you now hold both the best and the heaviest verdict this text contains. There is no worker the world loves more, no craft the world needs more, and no form that will ask more of your household. The families of weavers learn one habit above all the others, and I give it to you now, and it is not a figure of speech. Watch your weaver's hands. The hands say what the weaver will not.

You will ask, because every household asks: which form is best? None. Which is greatest? None. Six doors, one house. But if you ask an assessor which form costs its worker most, you will find that on this one question, in every province, from every assessor who has ever carried the bowls, you get the same answer.

You have just read it.

V · The Flowbinders

The bowls bear the louder water.

Nearly every vessel that has ever been tested answers with one flow. One Shape, one door, a life's work behind it.

And then there are the others.

Rarely, so rarely that an assessor can carry the bowls a whole working life and never once find one at a market day, a vessel answers twice. Two flows in one child. Not a deeper vessel, mind: Size is Size, and a Flowbinder's water may run any depth at all. Two doors. The records call such vessels Flowbinders, and have done for as long as there was anything written to call them by, and no household in the world is so grand or so humble that the word will not eventually reach its kitchen the week after such a child is found in it.

Where two flows live in one vessel, they do not stay strangers. They marry. The work that comes of the pairing is not the first craft plus the second craft. It is a third thing, with its own nature, and the records name the pairings the old way, each fusion wearing halves of its parents' names. I set the table down whole, as it has come down to us, because a household should see the size of the country even if no one they love will ever walk in it:

Of Echocraft: with Voidshaping, **Echoshaping**. With Streambinding, **Echobinding**. With Lifeweaving, **Echoweaving**. With Loreforging, **Lorecraft**. With Essencebending, **Essencecraft**.

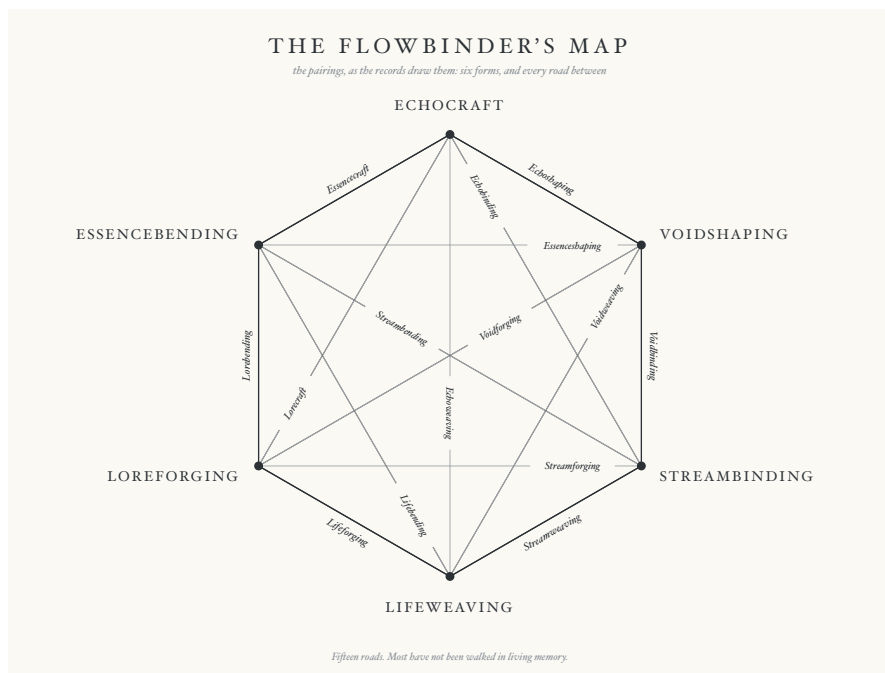
Of Voidshaping: with Streambinding, **Voidbinding**. With Lifeweaving, **Voidweaving**. With Loreforging, **Voidforging**. With Essencebending, **Essenceshaping**.

Of Streambinding: with Lifeweaving, **Streamweaving**. With Loreforging, **Streamforging**. With Essencebending, **Streambending**.

Of Lifeweaving: with Loreforging, **Lifeforging**. With Essencebending, **Lifebending**.

And of Loreforging with Essencebending, **Lorebending**.

And because names in a row make a poor picture of a marriage, the map as well, as it has always been drawn: six forms, and every road between.



Fifteen names. Do not be misled by the tidiness of the table. Most of these pairings have not been seen in living memory. Some may not have been seen truly at all, only claimed. The table is a record, not a promise.

Now the honesty I began in the vessel chapter, and that assessors as a company have been slow to say aloud.

We are poor at finding them.

The bowls catch a flow. They catch the flow that speaks first and speaks loudest, and there, very often, they stop. A second flow, running under the first, is a thing the bowls were never sure instruments for, and a quiet second flow under a loud first one is beyond them more often than it is not. The bowls hear the louder water. We read what we hear, we deliver the verdict, and we go home content, and now and then, in some kitchen we have already left, there is more in a child than the verdict said.

So the count of Flowbinders the records hold is a count of the found. How many walked their whole lives uncounted, found late by some sharp-eyed kin, or found by no one at all, no assessor can tell you, and I distrust anyone with a confident answer. What I can tell your household is what this means at your own table. The verdict you were given is true. It is not always complete. If, in the years after the bowls, you see in your child a thing the verdict does not explain, some second current under the first, do not decide the bowls have settled the question. Bring the child back. Ask again. The bowls do not mind being wrong, and neither, on this subject, does any assessor worth the name.

VI · The Gentle Draw

Leave the surface as you found it.

Nearly done. You have been patient, and I have kept the shortest chapter for last.

You now know what your child is, as well as bowls and pages can say it: a vessel of a certain Shape and a certain Size, standing at the bottom of a ladder of draws, before one door of six, or, once in a great while, two. You know what the work will ask and what it will cost, and you know the one fact under all of it, that every draw troubles a surface which is not water but time, and that the trouble runs into years you will never see in both directions.

So here, at the end, is what a household should hope for. Not depth. You have no say in the depth, and you now know better than to spend your love against it. Not the rare second door. Hope instead for the thing the bowls cannot read and the years can build: steadiness. A quiet hand. A child who becomes the kind of worker the village blesses at planting and forgets to mention otherwise, whose work sits so lightly on the world that no one glances at the standing water when they pass.

Teach them as you would teach any child who has been handed something heavy. Carry it slowly. Use both hands. Set it down often.

The rest is the teacher's, and the years', and the child's own. Nothing is asked of your household but the smallest hand your child can learn. The whole of the craft and the whole of the reverence fit inside two words, the same two every teacher says at the start of every lesson. I learned them from wet brass and other people's

kitchens. I leave them with your family, with my respect, and with the bowls dried and packed.

Draw gently.

The Legends

The bowls find a Flowbinder once in a working lifetime. The stories find them more often. *Stories From The Still Lake* gathers three legends: a commander who would not break, a wedding guest nobody will recall, and a healer who carved his own confession in stone. It is free at **billmckibbin.com**, and you are welcome to share it with anyone who loves a good legend.

The Chronicles Begin

The Chronicles of the Still Lake, an epic fantasy series, begins with Book One on **December 1, 2026**. You are on the list, so you will have word the day it arrives.

Read the Chronicles Early

A small group of readers receives each book of the Chronicles before release day, in exchange for honest reviews. If you want the books early, reply to any of my emails and ask to join the advance team.